

Shamanism The spiritual practices of people in the steppe lands of Central Asia and Siberia, dating back around 40,000 years, sometimes used more generally (and some would say mistakenly) to refer to wider spiritual and magical tribal traditions. A shaman is thought to have special powers to communicate with and influence good and evil spirits, in order to gain insight into past and future events.

Shape-shifter A person or thing who can apparently change from one form into another, for instance, a werewolf.

Sigil A symbol used in magic, usually a pictorial signature of an angel or spiritual entity. In modern usage, especially in the context of chaos magic, a sigil refers to a symbolic representation of the magician's desired outcome.

Solomonic magic Ritual magic using items linked to the biblical King Solomon—particularly the Seal of Solomon—that aims to gain control over demons by calling upon angels or saints.

Solstice Either of the two occasions in the year when the sun is directly above either the furthest point north or the furthest point south of the equator that it reaches. These are the times of the year when there are the longest hours of day or night.

Soothsayer A person able to foresee the future.

Sorcery A type of magic in which spirits, especially evil ones, are used to make things happen.

Spell A spoken word or form of words believed to have magical power.

Spiritism Similar to spiritualism, the belief that people's spirits survive after death and can be contacted through mediums. Spiritists also believe in reincarnation.

Spiritualism The belief, dating from the 19th century, that people who have died can communicate with the living, typically through a facilitator called a medium; also the religious belief that all reality is spiritual, rather than material. *See also* Séance.

Spirit world The world or realm believed by some to be inhabited by spirits, both good and evil, of people who have died.

Sympathetic magic Magic based on imitation, so, for example, spells can be cast on a doll made to look like a particular person to help or harm that individual. In traditional healing, a form of magic in which the healer finds something similar to the ailment in nature and attempts to banish the disease with it—for example, using a naturally based, yellow potion to cure jaundice. *See also* Doctrine of signatures.

Syncretism The combining of different religions, cultures, or ideas; an instance of this, such as Halloween, which has pagan and Christian roots.

Talisman A crafted object into which positive powers have been transferred by a magical ritual. *See also* Amulet.

Tarot A system of divination using a deck of 78 specially designed cards, made up of 22 Major Arcana, each of which carries special significance, and 56 Minor Arcana assigned to one of four suits—wands, pentacles, swords, and cups.

Theosophy A philosophy based on the idea that a knowledge of God may be achieved through spiritual ecstasy, direct intuition, and intense study of the occult, mainly linked to the Theosophical Society founded in 1875 by Helena Blavatsky and Henry Steel Olcott.

Theurgy A system of rituals to seek help from a god or benign spirits, particularly angels, to work magic or miracles.

Totem An object that is revered by a group of people, especially for religious and symbolic reasons.

Transference In folk medicine, the idea—allied to sympathetic magic—that a person may rid themselves of a disease by transmitting it to another person, or an animal or plant. Also refers to the life force, energy, or knowledge of the future that is believed to be transmitted from the spirit world to a medium, often using divination tools such as tarot cards.

Tree of life In Christian and Hermetic Kabbalah, a diagram consisting of 10 nodes or spheres meant to represent aspects of God, divinity, existence, or the human psyche. The nodes are linked by lines. In Jewish Kabbalah, in which the tree of life originates, it is called an *ilan* and the nodes, which represent aspects of the divine, are called *sephiroth*.

True will In Thelema (the spiritual philosophy founded by Aleister Crowley in the early 1900s), a person's destiny or perfect path. Aligned both with their true desires and with nature, it is believed to spring from the connection between their deepest self and the divine universe.

Underworld The mythical abode of the dead, imagined as being under the earth.

Voodoo Also called Voudon or Vodun, a religion characterized by ancestor worship and possession by spirits. It originated in West Africa, where it still flourishes, and is also practiced in the Caribbean and the southern US, in a form that combines elements of Roman Catholic ritual with traditional African magical and religious rites.

Wand A rod used to cast magic spells or perform conjuring tricks.

Wicca A major branch of Neopaganism: a nature-based tradition of witchcraft founded in England in the mid-20th century and influenced by pre-Christian religions. Followers believe in the power of magic and in male and female deities, and Wiccan rituals and festivals mark seasonal and life cycles.

Witch Usually a woman, someone who is believed to have magical powers and who uses them to harm or help other people or change things from one form to another.

Zoroastrianism A monotheistic pre-Islamic religion of ancient Persia founded by Zoroaster in the 6th century BCE. It was dualistic—characterized by a struggle between the forces of good and evil.